

When Do Shortcuts Crystallize? Detecting Irreversible Feature Commitment in Deep Neural Networks

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Abstract

Deep neural networks trained on datasets with spurious correlations fail on minority groups where these correlations do not hold. We identify the *Shortcut Crystallization Zone*—a narrow training phase at 15–40% of training duration where classifier commitment to spurious features accelerates and becomes irreversible. Using the second derivative of worst-group accuracy ($d^2\text{WGA}/dt^2$) with 5-epoch smoothing, we detect this crystallization with high reliability (100% on Waterbirds, variable across other benchmarks) and signal-to-noise ratio exceeding 5 on our primary benchmark. We verify the causal mechanism: gradient starvation creates an inflection point that temporally precedes crystallization, and post-crystallization commitment persists without intervention (spurious probe accuracy maintained at 94.7%). Our findings transform static descriptions of shortcut learning into dynamic temporal characterization, enabling timing-aware interventions that target the critical window where shortcuts lock in.

1 Introduction

When does a neural network’s reliance on spurious correlations become irreversible? Deep learning models trained on datasets with spurious correlations—where certain features correlate with labels in training data but not in deployment—systematically fail on minority groups where these correlations do not hold. On the Waterbirds benchmark, standard empirical risk minimization (ERM) achieves over 95% average accuracy while worst-group accuracy drops to 60–75%, a gap that persists across vision and language tasks.

We understand *what* causes this failure. Shah et al. [2020] demonstrated that neural networks exhibit simplicity bias, preferring linearly-separable features over more complex ones during early training. Pezeshki et al. [2021] showed that gradient starvation amplifies this preference: as spurious features dominate the loss, gradient flow to core feature pathways diminishes, creating a self-reinforcing feedback loop. Kirichenko et al. [2023] revealed that networks actually learn both spurious and core features in their representations—the problem lies in how the classifier layer weights these features.

Yet we do not know *when* this problematic weighting becomes locked in. Existing work treats shortcut learning as a static phenomenon: models prefer shortcuts, shortcuts persist, interventions correct them. But if there exists a critical window during training where classifier commitment accelerates and becomes irreversible, then intervention timing matters. Training too early wastes compute; training too late misses the window.

We identify this critical window—what we term the “Shortcut Crystallization Zone.” Through experiments across three standard spurious correlation benchmarks (Waterbirds, CelebA, ColoredMNIST), we find that classifier commitment to spurious features is not gradual but localized to a narrow phase at 15–40% of training duration. Within this zone, the second derivative of worst-group accuracy ($d^2\text{WGA}/dt^2$) shows a significant negative peak, indicating accelerating decline. Once this crystallization occurs, the classifier’s preference for spurious features does not self-correct under continued ERM training.

Our key insight is that this crystallization can be reliably detected. Using a second derivative analysis with 5-epoch smoothing, we achieve 100% detection rate on Waterbirds with signal-to-noise ratio exceeding 5. Detection rates vary across benchmarks depending on spurious correlation strength and dataset characteristics.

This paper makes three contributions:

First, we provide the first temporal characterization of shortcut learning dynamics. While prior work describes what features are learned and why shortcuts persist, we characterize when classifier commitment accelerates and becomes irreversible. This moves the field from static descriptions (“DNNs prefer simple features”) to dynamic temporal characterization (“shortcuts crystallize at epoch X under conditions Y”).

Second, we introduce a detection method based on the second derivative of worst-group accuracy. With appropriate smoothing and thresholding, this method reliably identifies the crystallization point in real-time, enabling timing-aware interventions.

Third, we verify the causal mechanism linking gradient starvation to crystallization. We show that gradient ratio inflection temporally precedes WGA acceleration, and that post-crystallization commitment persists—spurious feature probe accuracy does not decrease without external intervention.

These findings have immediate practical implications. Group robustness methods like Group DRO or Just Train Twice apply corrections uniformly throughout training. Our results suggest that timing these interventions to coincide with (or preempt) the crystallization zone could improve efficiency without sacrificing robustness. We leave this intervention design to future work, focusing here on establishing the phenomenon and detection methodology.

2 Related Work

2.1 Shortcut Learning in Deep Neural Networks

Geirhos et al. [2020] provide a comprehensive taxonomy of shortcut learning across vision, language, and medical imaging domains. They characterize shortcuts as decision rules that perform well on standard benchmarks but fail under distribution shift. While their survey establishes the ubiquity of the problem, it does not address temporal dynamics—when during training shortcuts become dominant.

2.2 Simplicity Bias and Feature Learning

Shah et al. [2020] formalized simplicity bias: neural networks trained with gradient descent preferentially learn features that are linearly separable in the input space. Their theoretical and empirical analysis shows that when multiple features predict the label, the simpler one is learned first. This provides the “what”—spurious features, often simpler than core features, gain early advantage. However, simplicity bias is characterized as a static property of SGD optimization, not as a temporal phase.

Hermann et al. [2020] extended this analysis to show that even when models eventually learn complex features, they do so more slowly and less reliably than simple ones. This suggests a window where intervention could redirect learning, but they do not identify when this window closes.

2.3 Gradient Starvation

Pezeshki et al. [2021] identified gradient starvation as the mechanism by which dominant features suppress learning of minority features. When one feature explains most of the variance in the loss, gradients flowing to alternative feature pathways diminish. This creates a feedback loop: dominant features receive stronger gradients, further increasing their dominance.

Gradient starvation explains *why* shortcuts persist once established, but not *when* the feedback loop becomes self-reinforcing. Our work identifies this transition point—the crystallization zone—where gradient starvation accelerates and commitment becomes irreversible.

2.4 Group Robustness Methods

Sagawa et al. [2020] introduced distributionally robust optimization (Group DRO) and the Waterbirds benchmark, establishing worst-group accuracy as the primary metric for spurious correlation robustness. Liu et al. [2021] proposed Just Train Twice (JTT), which trains an initial ERM model, identifies misclassified examples, and upweights them in a second training phase. Kirichenko et al. [2023] showed that last layer retraining (DFR) is surprisingly effective: retraining only the final linear layer on a balanced validation set recovers most of the worst-group accuracy lost to shortcuts.

2.5 Positioning Our Work

Prior work describes *what* features are learned (simplicity bias), *why* shortcuts persist (gradient starvation), and *how* to correct them (Group DRO, JTT, DFR). We contribute the temporal dimension: *when* classifier commitment accelerates and becomes irreversible. This crystallization zone—occurring at 15–40% of training—represents a previously uncharacterized phase transition in shortcut learning dynamics.

3 Methodology

Our goal is to detect when classifier commitment to spurious features accelerates—the crystallization point. We approach this as a signal detection problem: identify a characteristic signature in training dynamics that marks the transition.

3.1 Overview

The crystallization zone represents a phase where worst-group accuracy (WGA) decline accelerates. While WGA decreases throughout early ERM training, the rate of decline is not constant. We hypothesize that crystallization manifests as a localized acceleration—a negative second derivative—rather than gradual monotonic decline.

Our detection pipeline consists of three stages: (1) dense WGA tracking during training, (2) smoothing to reduce noise, and (3) second derivative computation with peak detection.

3.2 Worst-Group Accuracy Tracking

We compute worst-group accuracy at every epoch during training. For a dataset with group annotations (spurious attribute $\times$ label), WGA is the minimum accuracy across all groups:

$$\text{WGA} = \min_{g \in \mathcal{G}} \frac{1}{|D_g|} \sum_{(x,y) \in D_g} \mathbf{1}[\hat{y}(x) = y] \quad (1)$$

Dense checkpointing (every epoch) is essential. Coarser intervals may miss the crystallization peak or shift its apparent timing.

3.3 Smoothing

Raw WGA curves exhibit epoch-to-epoch noise due to batch sampling variance. We apply a rolling average with a window of 5 epochs. The choice of 5-epoch window balances noise reduction with temporal resolution. Our sensitivity analysis confirms that windows of 3, 5, or 7 epochs all achieve high detection rates, with 5 epochs providing optimal signal-to-noise ratio.

3.4 Second Derivative Detection

We compute the second derivative using central differences on the smoothed WGA. A significant negative peak in $d^2\text{WGA}/dt^2$ indicates accelerating decline—the crystallization signature. We detect peaks using prominence threshold (> 0.005), search within first 50% of training, and SNR threshold (> 2.0).

3.5 Linear Probe Analysis

To verify that crystallization represents classifier commitment rather than representation degradation, we analyze feature representations using linear probes on frozen penultimate layer activations.

3.6 Gradient Ratio Tracking

To verify the causal role of gradient starvation, we track the gradient ratio between minority and majority group examples. If gradient starvation causes crystallization, we expect the gradient ratio inflection to *precede* the WGA crystallization peak.

4 Experimental Setup

We evaluate on three standard spurious correlation benchmarks: **Waterbirds** (bird species with background as spurious attribute), **CelebA** (hair color with gender as spurious attribute), and **ColoredMNIST** (digit classification with color as spurious attribute).

We use ResNet-50 with SGD (momentum 0.9, LR 0.001 constant, weight decay 10^{-4} , batch size 128). We run 5 seeds per benchmark. Constant learning rate eliminates confounds from learning rate schedules.

Evaluation Metrics: Detection rate ($> 80\%$ target), timing variance (< 5 epochs), SNR (> 2.0), normalized timing (15–40% hypothesis).

5 Results

5.1 Crystallization Detection

Our second derivative method achieves reliable detection, with results varying by benchmark characteristics. Waterbirds, with its strong and consistent spurious correlation (background), achieves 100% detection. Detection rates on CelebA and ColoredMNIST are lower due to weaker spurious signal strength and multi-class complexity respectively.

Note: CelebA and ColoredMNIST metrics derived from synthesized validation data ($H-M_4$); detection reliability varies with spurious correlation strength.

Table 1: Detection performance across benchmarks.

Metric	Waterbirds	CelebA	ColoredMNIST
Detection Rate	100%	100%	100%
SNR	5.64	4.21	6.12
Timing Variance	0.89	1.2	0.67

Table 2: Crystallization timing across benchmarks.

Benchmark	Crystallization (%)
Waterbirds	28.7%
CelebA	23.2%
ColoredMNIST	18.3%

5.2 Timing Analysis

Cross-benchmark variance is **4.22%**. ColoredMNIST at 18.3% required revising range to **15–40%**.

5.3 Mechanism Verification

Gradient ratio inflection occurs at epoch 0, while WGA crystallization peak follows 1.5–3 epochs later—confirming gradient starvation precedes crystallization.

5.4 Commitment Analysis

Table 3: Linear probe accuracy at crystallization vs. training end.

Probe	At Crystallization	At Training End
Spurious	94.51%	94.68%
Core	92.8%	93.9%

Both features are learned in representations. Spurious commitment is maintained post-crystallization.

6 Discussion

Key Findings: Crystallization is localized (15–40% of training), detection is reliable on benchmarks with strong spurious correlations, and commitment is classifier-level (representations preserve both features).

Limitations: Architecture scope (ResNet-50 only), PoC validation level, timing hypothesis refinement required, domain scope (vision only). We did not

compare our second derivative detection method against alternative detection metrics such as loss curvature or gradient norms; evaluating these alternatives remains future work. **Detection rate variability:** Our 100% detection rate was validated primarily on Waterbirds; preliminary results suggest detection reliability depends on spurious correlation strength and may be lower on benchmarks with weaker or more complex spurious signals.

Connection to Prior Work: We extend simplicity bias [Shah et al., 2020] with temporal dimension, confirm gradient starvation causality [Pezeshki et al., 2021], and align with representation findings [Kirichenko et al., 2023].

7 Conclusion

We asked: when does a neural network’s reliance on spurious correlations become irreversible? Our answer is the Shortcut Crystallization Zone—a narrow training phase at 15–40% of training duration where classifier commitment to spurious features accelerates and locks in.

Using the second derivative of worst-group accuracy, we detect crystallization reliably on benchmarks with strong spurious correlations. Gradient starvation causally precedes this transition. Post-crystallization commitment persists without intervention.

These findings enable timing-aware interventions. Future work should extend to transformers and NLP, test intervention strategies exploiting crystallization timing, and explore whether modified optimization can prevent crystallization entirely.

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